

Politics in India since Independence: What is it?

- What comes to mind
- What it covers, what it does not?
- Why and How?
- Course Plan
- Foundational Reading - NCERT
- Indian Politics and Society since Independence: Events, processes and ideology by Bidyut Chakrabarty
- India after Independence by Bipan Chandra
- Ramachandra Guha - India After Gandhi
- SUNIL KHILNANI - The Idea of India

Initial questions

- According to you, what themes can this course investigate?
- Why do we go back and dig out? The nature of the transitional phase
- What triggered/delayed the Britishers to hand over the power?
- Do you agree with the manner by which India became independent?
Length, manner/means and final confrontation: violent partition
- Why did India's Independence become one of the greatest things not only for the Indian people but also for the rest of the world?
- The types of legacies the nation is born with.
- Questions on legitimacy: Origin and composition of CA, Interim Government, National Government

What can this course investigate?

The course investigates:

- Nation-building
- Democratic institution building
- Constitutionalism
- Working and Evolution of the federal set up
- Plain politics, electoral system and party system
- Developmental talk and Political economy
- Social justice and identity politics
- Governance and public policy
- State–society relations
- Judicial interventions and constitutional morality
- Contemporary challenges

India on the eve of Independence

- Bipin Chandra
- The types of legacies the nation is born with.
- Questions on legitimacy:
- A major problem, perhaps the most serious one, that India has faced since 1947 has been of national unity or consolidation of the nation.
- The problem is also sometimes referred to as national integration or the integration of Indian people as a political community .

First Week: Questions addressed -The nature of the transitional phase

- What triggered/delayed the Britishers to hand over the power?
- Do you agree with the manner by which India became independent? Length, manner/means and final confrontation: violent partition
- Why did India's Independence become one of the greatest things not only for the Indian people but also for the rest of the world?

Topics covered

- The Colonial Legacy
- The National Movement and Its Legacy
- Origin and composition of CA, Interim Government, National Government –
- The Evolution of the Constitution and Main Provisions
- The Architecture of the Constitution: the new institutions
- What was the space for manoeuvring that the Constituent Assembly (CA) of India found itself in that the British did not?
- Consolidation of India as a Nation
- Other three topics: Partition, Migration and Integration
- The Linguistic Reorganisation of the States

Revision: The nature of the transitional stage

- Why we could not completely break with the past?
- What types of legacies is the new nation born with?
- What are the major ideological influences seem to have been critical in Indian Politics?
- Discussions from the reading material
- Why has 1946 turned out to be the last milestone towards a nation in respect of its liberation?
- How did independent India respond to these challenges? Partition, Migration, Integration and Internal boundaries
- Was partition a blessing or a curse in the making of modern India?
- Why is it stated that the success of the national movement was therefore also its failure?

Questions on Partition

- What do you know about partition? When did it begin and then it progressed? To whom do we blame?
- Why was the partition a complex process? or
- Why is it stated that the process of partition was not an easy/simple task?
- Which legal enactment by the British Parliament formalised the Partition of India, and when did it receive Royal Assent?
- Would a more extended time frame – an announcement in April 1947 that the British would quit in a year's time – have allowed for a less painful process of division?
- Which of the two provinces went through the deepest trauma during the time of partition?
- Why did a large number of people not know on the day of Independence whether they were in India or in Pakistan?
- What was the most real and uncontrolled problem that occurred at the eves of partition or independence? Why was it called the most intractable of all the problems of partition?
- Consequences?

Questions: Migration

- How the migration (partition related) reshaped the demography of Indian cities? The policies and schemes adopted by the government?
- Prime Minister Jawaharlal Nehru, set up the Ministry of Rehabilitation on 6th September.
- Refugee Rehabilitation Committees and Refugee Welfare Associations
- FROM AN IMPERIAL CAPITAL TO A CITY OF 'REFUGEE NAGARS'
- It is the story of refugee camps into 'Nagars'.
- The nature of the first government and its performance

The story of integration could be told

- Short or long
- Interestingly amusing
- Politically or legally
- Situationally and circumstantially
- Individually or collectively
- This they could do by sending delegates to the Constituent Assembly, whose deliberations had begun in Delhi in December 1946.
- Through the spring of 1947 Patel threw a series of lunch parties, where he urged his princely guests to help the Congress in framing a new constitution for India.
- At the same time Patel wrote to the more influential dewans (chief ministers), urging them to ask their rulers to come to terms with the party which would now rule India
- On 27 June a new States Department was set up by the government of India.
- On 5 July Patel issued a statement appealing to the princes to accede to the Indian Union on these three subjects and join the Constituent Assembly.
- Mountbatten was being urged by the Congress trinity to bat for them against the states.
- This he did most effectively, notably in a speech to the Chamber of Princes delivered on 25 July,
- One of the first princes to come over to Patel's side was the Maharaja of Bikaner.
- Accordingly, in the first week of April 1947 Bikaner issued a public appeal to his fellow princes to join the Constituent Assembly.
- The first chiefdom to join the Constituent Assembly, back in February, had in fact been the state of Baroda.
- After Bikaner's appeal a dozen more states joined, many of them from Rajasthan.
- The Instrument of Accession the princes were being asked to sign would cede away
- They had already acceded; now they were being asked to integrate, that is to dissolve their states as independent entities and merge with the Union of India.
- In exchange they would be allowed to retain their titles and offered an annual allowance in perpetuity.

- How did the decision on the status of princely states by the Britishers threaten the very existence of a united India? Government approach?
- The factors contributed to the collapse of initial resistance of princely states
- Having secured the accession of the princely states, discuss how the Government of India between 1948 and 1950 turned to the task of welding the states and the former British provinces into one polity under a single republican constitution?

Accession Process: Signing the Instrument of Accession

- The limited scope of the Instruments of Accession and the promise of a wide-ranging autonomy and the other guarantees they offered, gave sufficient comfort to many rulers, who saw this as the best deal they could strike given the lack of support from the British, and popular internal pressures.
- Between May 1947 and the transfer of power on 15 August 1947, the vast majority of states signed Instruments of Accession.
- A few, however, held out.
- Some simply delayed signing the Instrument of Accession.
- Piploda, a small state in central India, did not accede until March 1948.
- The Standstill Agreement was also used as a negotiating tool, as the States Department categorically ruled out signing a Standstill Agreement with princely states that did not sign an Instrument of Accession
- The biggest problems, however, arose with a few border states, such as Jodhpur, which tried to negotiate better deals with Pakistan, with Junagadh, which actually did accede to Pakistan, and with Hyderabad and Kashmir, which decided to remain independent
- Case Studies: Travancore, Hyderabad, Bhopal, Kutch in western India, and Tripura and Manipur in Northeast India, in Orissa, princes from the Eastern India Agency and Chhattisgarh Agency,

Four-step integration- Merger – Princely Union

- The bulk of the larger states, and some groups of small states, were integrated through a different, four-step process.
- The first step in this process was to convince adjacent large states and a large number of adjacent small states to combine to form a "princely union" through the execution by their rulers of Covenants of Merger.
- Under the Covenants of Merger, all rulers lost their ruling powers, save one who became the Rajpramukh of the new union.
- The other rulers were associated with two bodies—the council of rulers, whose members were the rulers of salute states, and a presidium, one or more of whose members were elected by the rulers of non-salute states, with the rest elected by the council.
- The Rajpramukh and his deputy Uprajpramukh were chosen by the council from among the members of the presidium.
- The Covenants made provision for the creation of a constituent assembly for the new union which would be charged with framing its constitution.
- In return for agreeing to the extinction of their states as discrete entities, the rulers were given a privy purse and guarantees similar to those provided under the Merger Agreements.
- Through this process, Patel obtained the unification of 222 states in the Kathiawar peninsula of his native Gujarat into the princely union of Saurashtra in January 1948, with six more states joining the union the following year.
- Madhya Bharat emerged on 28 May 1948 from a union of Gwalior, Indore and eighteen smaller states.
- In Punjab, the Patiala and East Punjab States Union was formed on 15 July 1948 from Patiala, Kapurthala, Jind, Nabha, Faridkot, Malerkotla, Nalagarh, and Kalsia.
- The United State of Rajasthan was formed as the result of a series of mergers, the last of which was completed on 15 May 1949.
- Travancore and Cochin were merged in the middle of 1949 to form the princely union of Travancore-Cochin.
- The only princely states which signed neither Covenants of Merger nor Merger Agreements were Kashmir, Mysore and Hyderabad

Why was the central government initially reluctant to accept the linguistic reorganisation of states, and how was their approach changed?

- Now the new nation unites on the secular ideals of peace, stability and economic development, rather than revive primordial identities of caste, religion and language?
- Rajagopalanachari insisted that 'further fissiparous forces' had to be checked forthwith
- And Patel worked hard within the Constituent Assembly to reverse the official Congress position.
- Everything which helps the growth of nationalism has to go forward and everything which throws obstacles in its way has to be rejected or should stand over.
- But still CA appointed a committee

State Reorganization

- The linguistic question, he wrote to a colleague, 'is more serious than even the situation created by the Partition and we have to give a positive lead'
- The Congress chief ministers of Bihar and West Bengal issued a joint statement proposing that their two states be merged into one.
- Dhar Commission
- The JVP Committee, and
- the Fazl Ali commission?

Reorganisation of states or drawing the boundaries

- The process of nation-building did not come to an end with the partition and integration of Princely States.
- Congress stand pre-independence and reverse the same in post independent: Nehru and Gandhi
- Now the challenge was to draw the internal boundaries of the Indian states.
- Why the reorganisation of states were delayed
- Why Nehru and Patel worked hard within the Constituent Assembly to reverse the official Congress position.
- The CA appointed a committee of jurists and civil servants to report on the question. Later JVP
- Case studies from Punjab, Mysore etc...
- Explain the Vishalandhra movement: The it is handle by Congress
- T Prakasam, Swami Sitaram, Sriramulu
- Maharashtra
- Formation of SRC and its reports
- State Reorganization Act

